Source: Author's fieldwork, with T.M. Veeraraghav. Note: Veerendra Patil first became Congress chief minister in 1968, but switched to Congress (O) when the party split and continued as chief minister till 1971. The renaming of Karnataka in 1973 happened during the tenure of Devaraj Urs.
*Note: * Indicates those who were elected more than once as chief minister. ** Also referred to as Arasu. ***Also referred to as Idiga.*

Politically, this meant that many Lingayat leaders drifted away from the Congress in the 1970s. They realigned, instead, with the anti-Congress JP movement. This political shift by a dominant caste in Karnataka mirrored what happened further north in Gujarat. Just as the origins of the BJP's dominance in Gujarat can be traced to the dominant caste group of Patels moving away from the Congress in the early 1980s, the party's rise in Karnataka owes a great deal to the Lingayat vote shifting away from the Congress and towards the BJP from the 1990s.

Gujarat's political switch—of the Patels aligning with the JP movement—was also accelerated by the then Congress state chief Jinabhai Darjee carving out a new KHAM (Kshatriya Harijan Adivasi Muslim) social coalition for the party in the late 1970s.[23] Later, Chief Minister Madhavsinh Solanki built on the KHAM formula to drive Congress dominance in the early 1980s, further alienating the Patels, who felt they were being cut out of the power structure. Eventually, this caste group became the bedrock of the BJP's political rise in Gujarat. A similar shift happened with the Lingayats in Karnataka.

When Rajiv Gandhi Sacked a Chief Minister at an Airport: Veerendra Patil and the Origins of the BJP's Lingayat Breach

The career of Lingayat leader Veerendra Patil is instructive for understanding this change. He was the Congress chief minister at the time of the great split of 1969, and chose to leave the party with another two-time former chief minister, S. Nijalingappa. Patil continued as Karnataka chief minister in the Congress (O) that was formed in opposition to Indira Gandhi's Congress (I), before losing the elections in 1972. Through the 1970s, ex-Congress Lingayat leaders cast their lot with the anti-Congress Janata Party. However,